

NAXALITE MOVEMENT

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GAINING GROUND: Naxals wield power in 170 districts



fresh lease of life. On May Day in 1969, Sanyal announced the birth of CPI(ML).

In 1971, however, the government responded with Operation Steeplechase. This, coupled with Mazumdar's death in police custody a year later, destroyed Naxalism in West Bengal. Sanyal, who had fled to Andhra Pradesh, made it clear that the Naxalite movement was "an armed struggle not for land but state power". The party programme, adopted in 1970, made no mention of the struggle for the socio-economic uplift of the poor, and focused instead on guerrilla warfare. The issues of landless labourers and poor peasants were a plank for the Naxalites to build up a support system.

The debate on the use of firearms in advancing the Naxalite ideology resulted in the formation of many splinter groups. By 1980, in the effervescence that followed the Emergency, there were 30-odd Naxalite groups bearing such names as the pro- or anti- Lin Piao factions and the People's War Group. The profile of the cadres also began to change from that of bright idealistic youth to rural masses, even as the leaders were high-caste Hindus.

In 2004, the two violent factions—

the Maoists' Communist Centre and the People's War Group—joined hands to form the CPI(Maoist). Ever since, the Maoists have been operating as a unified force, setting off landmines, leading jailbreaks, assassinating politicians in and out of power and resorting to other extreme forms of lawlessness and violence. They adopt practices like torture, mutilation and killings after trials in kangaroo courts or the Jan Adalats. They are a regular force with squads patterned on army platoons. The 15,000 Maoists in India, with about 10,000 firearms, pose a big internal security challenge. They are active and wield influence in 170 of the 602 districts spread over 16 of the 33 states. The backing of local tribes makes it difficult for the government to contain them.

With the radicals developing military capabilities like mobile guerrilla warfare, potential investment destinations—particularly for the mineral extraction industry—situated in Naxalite-dominated areas in Andhra Pradesh and West Bengal may become unviable. An unanswered question mark in India's democratic polity, Naxalism is not merely a law-and-order problem. It has to be addressed simultaneously on the political, security, development and public-perception management fronts in a holistic manner. But as the government grapples with the challenge, Naxalites strengthen their sway. ■

KANU SANYAL, Naxal leader, 1977

"Communists can't have views divorced from reality. If your principles are not real, don't trust them."